



BEFORE

The Southern economy relied heavily on cotton exports, mostly to Britain. Before the war, these had earned large amounts of hard currency. However, the dominance of cotton-growing (see [Slave ownership](#)) suppressed the South's industrial capacity.

RISING PRODUCTION

Boosted by Eli Whitney's invention of [the cotton gin](#) for separating the fibers from the seeds, Southern **cotton production soared** during the 19th century. From 720,000 bales in 1830, it rose to 2.85 million bales in 1850 and was still rising at the outbreak of the Civil War. By then, the slave plantations of the South were the source of **75 percent** of the world's commercially grown cotton.

FAILED DIPLOMACY

The Confederates hoped that **"King Cotton" diplomacy** would force Britain to intervene on their behalf because, without Southern cotton, British textile mills would be idle. They underestimated the strength of **British anti-slavery sentiment** and the ability of British industrialists to find alternative sources of cotton in India, Egypt, and Argentina. Hopes of French intervention were similarly dashed.

The long and destructive nature of the Civil War, combined with the immense stakes involved—the fate of the Federal Union, the existence of the Confederate nation, and the status of slavery—made it a war of mass mobilization in both sections. Both sides in the conflict had to find the human, material, and technological resources for waging a war at a time of rapid industrialization, with its railroads, mass-produced weapons and equipment, and comparatively new technologies. Although the North possessed more of all of these things, the Confederate cause was by no means hopeless and doomed.

A well-resourced enemy

During the 19th century, the new era of rail and steam that marked the Industrial Revolution was centered in the Northern states, and a summary of economic and human resources shows their advantages. In 1860, the North possessed most of the country's manufacturing capacity, including 97 percent of firearms production. Altogether it had about 110,000 manufacturing enterprises and 1.3 million industrial workers. The future Confederacy could count only 18,000 factories employing 110,000 individuals. These Southern factories, however, did include the